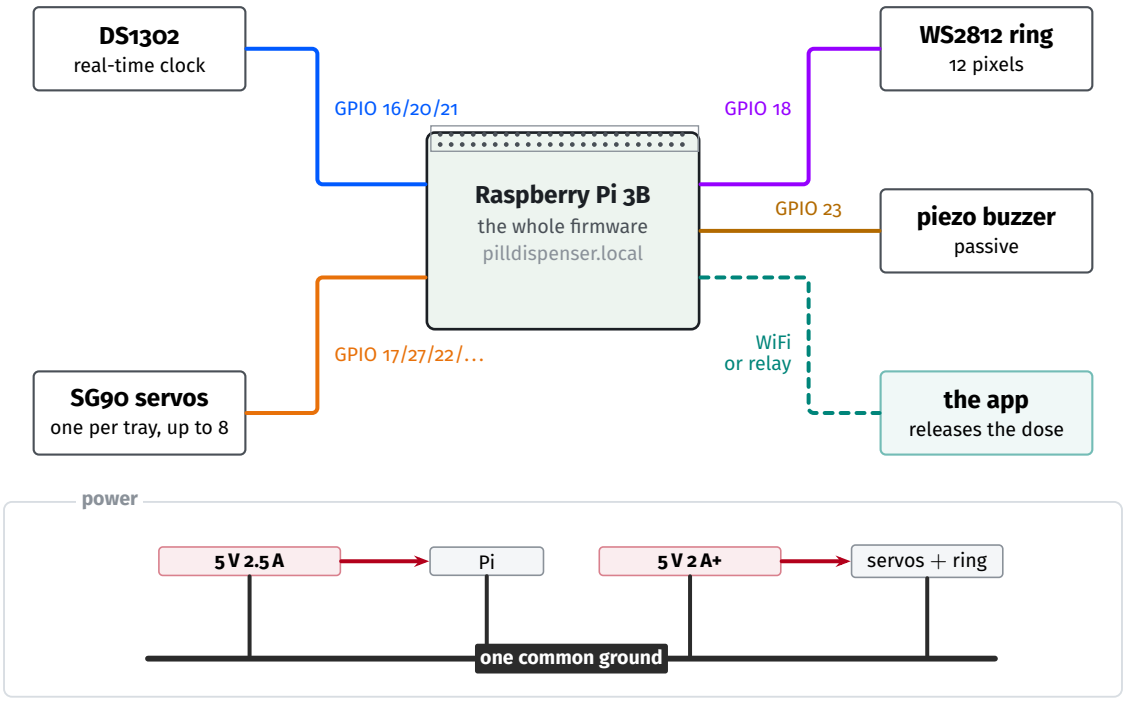
Building the dispenser

A bare Raspberry Pi 3B to a machine that asks for a dose and drops it

SnapCare · Team H1 · 16th e-ICON World Contest



Ten stages. Each one adds a single subsystem
and ends with the command that proves it works.

Matches `snapcare_dispenser/config.py`. Where the two disagree, that file is right.

Generated from `docs/assembly-guide.tex`.

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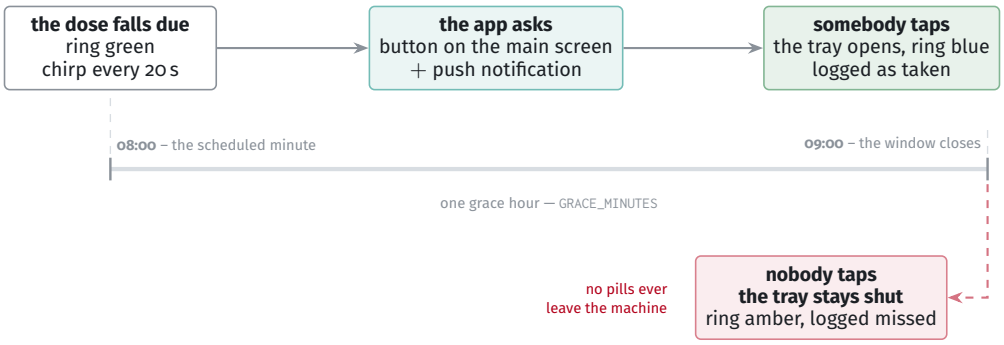
Read this first. Build in the order given, and test at the end of every stage. Each stage adds one subsystem and finishes with a command that proves it.

Wiring everything and then powering on means debugging five subsystems at once — and three of these five fail *silently*. A servo on the wrong pin, a ring that never lights, and an RTC with a dead cell all look identical from the outside: a machine sitting there doing nothing.

1 How a dose happens

Read this before you wire anything. It is the one thing about this machine that is not obvious from its parts, and every stage that follows makes more sense once you have it.

The dispenser asks before it drops. At the scheduled minute nothing leaves the hopper. The ring goes green, the buzzer starts chirping, and a release button appears on the app's main screen — also as a push notification, so the phone does not have to be open. The tray opens when somebody taps it.



Two consequences worth knowing before you build:

What changes	Why it is built this way
Nothing is ever dispensed unattended	Pills only leave the machine when somebody has said they are there to take them. A dose nobody asks for stays in the hopper, where the next person to look can still count it — rather than in a cup that may or may not have been emptied by somebody who then takes the next dose as well
The buzzer is not optional any more	It used to announce pills that had already dropped. Now it is the *prompt*: a machine that cannot chirp waits out the hour in silence and records a miss. Stage 2 fits it early for that reason

There is no button on this machine. Earlier builds had a momentary switch on GPIO 24 for confirming a dose after it dropped. It is gone, along with its two wires: the tap that releases the dose is the same tap that records it, so a second control confirming the first had nothing left to say. GPIO 24 is now free.

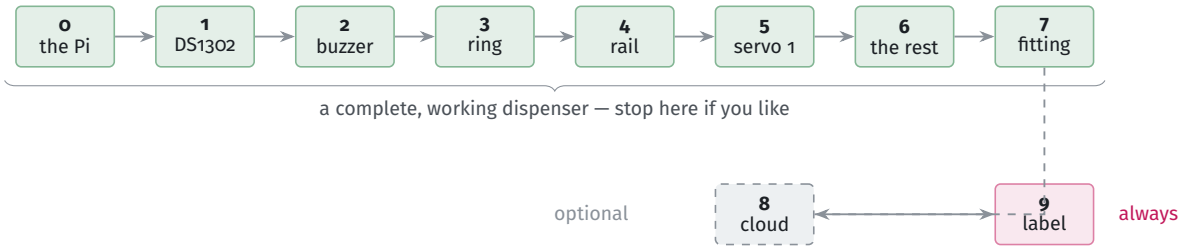
The release has to be able to reach the device — check you have one of the two paths

On the house WiFi the phone talks to `pilldispenser.local` directly, and no internet is involved. Away from the house it goes through the relay (Stage 8). A machine with neither working will chirp for an hour and then record a missed dose, which is safe and is not useful.

`--selftest` checks for both and fails if there is no path at all.

2 The build at a glance

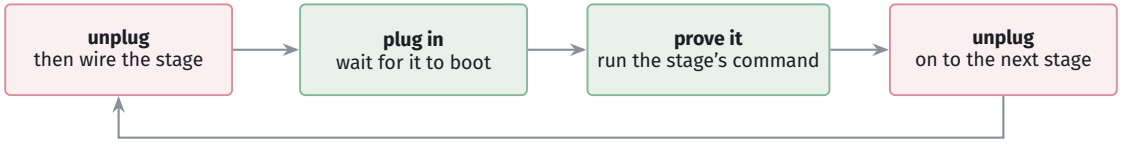
Nothing in stages 0 to 7 needs a network beyond the house.



	Subsystem	Where it lands	What it is for
—	DS1302	GPIO 16/20/21 + 3.3 V	knows the time after a power cut
—	piezo buzzer	GPIO 23, through 100 Ω	the prompt that fetches a person from another room
—	WS2812 ring	GPIO 18, through 330 Ω	green / blue / amber / violet
—	SG90 servos	GPIO 17, 27, 22, …	one per tray, signal only — never power

3 Powering up and down between stages

Every stage has the same rhythm, and it is worth saying once rather than repeating it eleven times.



So: **power off to wire, power on to test.** The stages below do not repeat the instruction — they say what to connect, and then what to run once it is back on.

Power state	What you may do
Unplugged	Connect or move any wire. Fit or remove the coin cell. Mount a servo horn
Running	Run the `curl` commands, watch the ring, listen to the buzzer, meter the servo rail. **Do not move a wire on a running Pi** — a signal pin brushed against 5 V is a dead GPIO, and a ground momentarily lifted while a servo is drawing current is a brown-out

"Unplug" means unplug. Not a shutdown that leaves the 5 V rail live, and not a hub switch. The Pi's GPIO pins are powered whenever the board is, and `sudo halt` does not change that.

The one exception is the servo supply, which is a separate plug: it can be left off through every stage up to Stage 4, and that is the safer way to work.

4 Bill of materials

	Qty	Part	Notes
	1	Raspberry Pi 3B	Any Pi with the 40-pin header works; the pin map assumes a 3B
	1	microSD card, 8 GB+	Raspberry Pi OS **Bookworm or newer** — the firmware drives WiFi through NetworkManager
	1	Pi power supply, 5 V 2.5 A	The official one. Servos do **not** come off this
	1 per tray	SG90 micro servo	Fit as many as you want hoppers, up to eight. The firmware accepts all eight, so a servo added later needs no change
	1	5 V supply, 2 A or better	Separate, for the servos and the ring
	1	1000 µF electrolytic, 10 V+	Across the servo rail, physically close to the servos
	1	Passive piezo buzzer	**Passive**, not an active beeper. The difference is not cosmetic and the two look identical in a listing — see Stage 2
	1	100 Ω resistor	In series with the buzzer
	1	WS2812 / NeoPixel ring, 12 px	16 and 24 also work — set `RING_PIXELS`
	1	330 Ω resistor	In the ring's data line, at the **ring** end
	1	DS1302 RTC module	The 5-pin board with a coin-cell holder. Read the accuracy note below
	—	Jumper wire, terminal blocks	Dupont leads are fine for the bench; solder or screw terminals for anything that gets carried
	—	a phone running the app	*Not a part*, but not optional either: it is what releases each dose. See page 3
	—	a relay, if you want cloud sync	*Not a part.* One container, deployed once for all your devices — see `../cloud_relay/`. Skip it and the dispenser is LAN-only

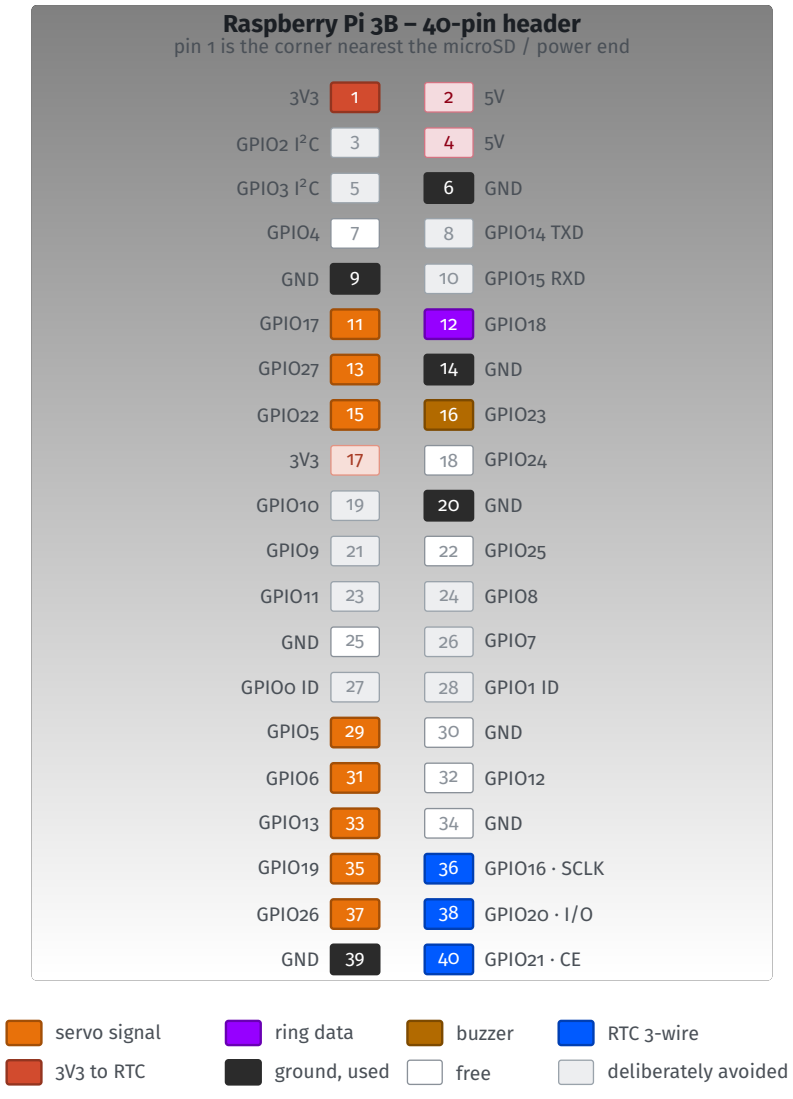
The DS1302 keeps worse time than you would expect

Its 32.768 kHz crystal is uncompensated, so a typical module drifts a few minutes a month, and more as the room warms and cools. That is good enough for the job it has here — carrying the time across a power cut until the Pi can reach an NTP server again — and it is *not* good enough as the only time source on a device that never sees a network. Commission this build on a network and leave it able to re-sync.

Fit the cell before you set the time, because what the chip remembers with the power off is the whole point of it. Most modules ship with a holder marked LIR2032; an ordinary non-rechargeable CR2032 is the safer choice and works, because the DS1302's built-in trickle charger stays switched off here.

5 The header, and every pin this build touches

Keep this page open while you wire. Everything is BCM numbering, which is what both GPIO libraries use; the small number inside each pad is the *physical* pin, which is what you actually count on the board.



The pins that were avoided, and what each costs

Pin	Why it is not used
GPIO 0, 1	HAT ID EEPROM. Driving them is how a HAT you plug in later fails to be detected
GPIO 2, 3	Permanent 1.8 kΩ pull-ups. A servo line idling high slams the horn at power-on, and on the RTC's bidirectional data line a *disconnected* wire would read as valid data
GPIO 14, 15	The serial console: the one way back into a Pi whose network setup you just broke
GPIO 7–11	SPI. Free today, gone the moment anyone adds an SPI display

GPIO 24 and 25 are free and unassigned. GPIO 24 carried the confirm button on earlier builds and has nothing on it now.

The eight tray pins

GPIO 17, 27, 22, 5, 6, 13, 19 and 26, in tray order. All eight are checked for clashes and against the pins that cost hardware, and the firmware accepts all eight out of the box — so however many hoppers this machine has today, the next one is **a plug**: no config edit, no restart with a different number.

If you would rather the device *refuse* a schedule for a tray that is not physically there, say how many are fitted:

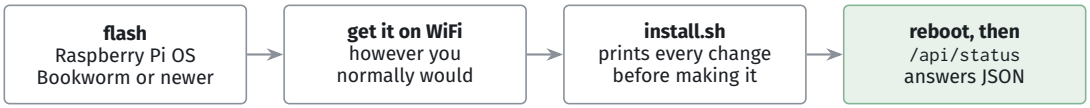
```
sudo systemctl edit snapcare-dispenser     # add:
     Environment=SNAPCARE_TRAYS=2
sudo systemctl restart snapcare-dispenser
```

Set it in the unit rather than on a command line. Running a second copy of the firmware by hand on a commissioned device fails anyway — port 80 is already taken by the service — and an environment variable typed at a shell does not survive the next reboot, which is the moment it stops being true.

`tests/test_servo.py` asserts all of this, and that no peripheral shares a pin with a servo.

6 Stage 0 — the Pi, before anything is wired to it

Do this stage first because it is the only one that can be done comfortably with the Pi on a desk and a keyboard attached. Once the servos are on it, every mistake costs a power-down.




```
git clone <this repo> && cd h1-SnapCare/pill_dispenser/rpi_firmware
sudo ./service/install.sh
sudo reboot
```

The installer is safe to re-run. It installs `python3-lgpio`, sets the hostname to `pilldispenser` and publishes it over avahi, writes the captive-portal DNS rule, installs `python3-cryptography` for cloud sync, and installs the systemd unit. The DS1302 needs no kernel overlay and no bus switched on: the firmware drives its three pins directly.

lgpio is the driver. pigpio is gone, and that is expected. pigpio was preinstalled on Raspberry Pi OS up to and including Bookworm, and disappeared at the Trixie rebase — Debian has never packaged the daemon, only the client, and the 64-bit images bootstrap from Debian. So `sudo apt install pigpio` fails on a current card, and there is no way to make it work.

`python3-lgpio` is the one that matters: it is preinstalled on every Raspberry Pi OS Lite image since 2023, and it is what will drive your pins. The installer still tries pigpio, because a Bookworm card has it and its DMA-timed servo pulses are genuinely steadier, and carries on when it is not there.

`/api/status` reports which one came up under `gpio.servo.timing`, and `--selftest` will not sign off a build that landed on neither.

Prove it

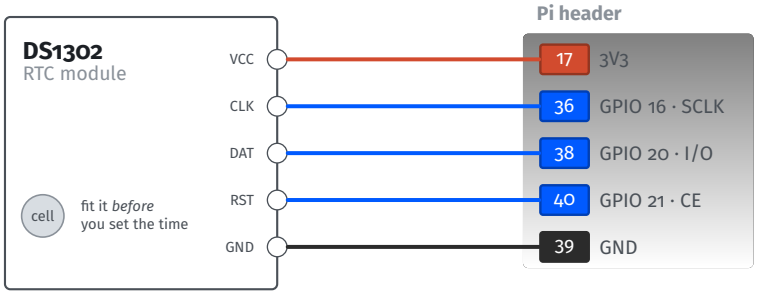
```
systemctl status snapcare-dispenser
curl -s http://localhost/api/status
```

You should get JSON. The `gpio` object will list what is missing, which right now is everything — correct, nothing is wired yet. The `cloud` object will say `unpaired`, which is also correct: no relay has been named.

The clock will most likely say `trusted` already, with `source: ntp`, because Stage 0 just put this Pi on WiFi. That is not the RTC working — nothing is wired to read yet. The coin cell is proved by the power-cut test at the end and by nothing before it.

7 Stage 1 — the DS1302

Five wires. Three of them land on the last three pins of the header's even-numbered row — 36, 38 and 40, at the far end from the microSD slot — with ground on pin 39 right beside them. The 3.3 V comes from pin 17.



3.3 V, not 5 V. The chip runs at either, but its `I/O` line *actively drives* back at whatever it is powered from, straight into a GPIO that is not 5 V tolerant.

Go by the silkscreen. The five terminals are in a different order on almost every board sold. Match the names, not the positions drawn here.

Physical pin numbers are in the pads. For where each one sits on the board, see the header map on page 6.

This is not a bus, and there is no kernel driver. The DS1302 is three plain GPIOs shifted by hand in software, so `i2cdetect`, `/dev/rtc0` and `hwclock` have nothing to say about it — the firmware is the only thing that can read this chip, and `/api/status` is where you look.

All three of its lines are deliberately kept off GPIO 2 and 3, whose permanent 1.8 kΩ pull-ups are wrong here in two separate ways. On the bidirectional `I/O` line the pull-up sources current the chip has to sink to show a zero — and a *floating* line then reads as a one, so a disconnected wire would look exactly like valid data. On the clock line it holds SCLK high before the pin is configured, breaking the chip's rule that SCLK must be low when CE rises.

Prove it

```
curl -s http://localhost/api/status     # the "clock" object: trusted, source, rtc
curl -X POST http://localhost/api/clock \
     -H 'Content-Type: application/json' -d '{"iso":"2026-07-29T09:15:00"}'
```

First check the chip was actually written. `clock.rtc.detail` must not say "no record of ever having been set" — if it does, the write did not reach the chip and there is no point going on to the power cut.

Then prove the only thing the chip is there for. **Pull the plug**, leave it a minute, and bring it back with the network unplugged: `trusted` must still be true and `source` must read `rtc`. A module that reads back the time you just set, but loses it across a power cut, has a dead cell or a cell holder that is not making contact.

`sudo shutdown now` does not test the coin cell

It halts the operating system and leaves the board powered: the 5 V and 3.3 V rails stay live, so the DS1302 keeps running on *your* 3.3 V from pin 17 and never falls back to its cell. The test passes and proves nothing.

Pull the power lead out. That is the only thing that puts the chip on its battery, which is the entire question this stage is asking.

This chip cannot answer the question the firmware asks

Worth understanding before trusting it, because it is the one place the DS1302 is a real step down from the DS3231 the Arduino build used.

A DS3231 has an *oscillator stop flag*: the hardware sets it whenever the oscillator has stopped, and it stays set until software clears it. That answers the only question worth asking — *did this*

chip lose time at some point, so that everything it has said since is invented?

The DS1302 has no such bit. Its clock-halt flag is a control, not a status: nothing in the hardware ever sets it, and its power-on state is documented as undefined. A clear flag means only "running right now", which is equally true of a chip that sat unpowered for a month and resumed counting from whatever was left in its registers.

So the firmware reconstructs the evidence instead. The DS1302 has 31 bytes of RAM in the *same battery-backed domain as the oscillator* — the coin cell holds both or neither. Setting the clock writes a token there, and on boot that token is present if and only if the cell has held continuously since. It is firmware convention rather than a hardware guarantee, and both of its failure modes fall towards *not* trusting the clock, which is the safe direction. `snapcare_dispenser/ds1302.py` is the whole argument.

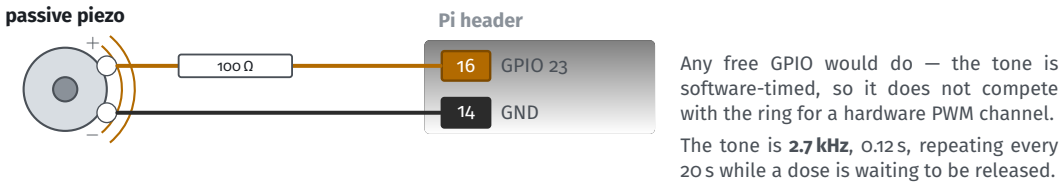
Nothing but this firmware ever sets the clock

On a DS3231 the kernel reads the chip and sets the system clock before userspace starts. The DS1302 has no such path on a Pi at all, so the firmware reads it itself at startup — which happens later, after systemd has already timestamped its own boot. That is the cost of the part.

Two things follow. `i2cdetect`, `/dev/rtc0` and `hwclock` have nothing to say about this chip, so `/api/status` is the only place to look; and `fake-hwclock` is no longer competing with a kernel RTC, so leaving it installed is harmless.

8 Stage 2 — the buzzer

Two wires and a resistor. This comes early because on this build the chirp is the prompt: it is what tells somebody there is a dose to release, and a machine that cannot make it waits out the hour and records a miss.



Passive, not active — they look the same and are not

The firmware makes the tone itself, driving the pin as a 2.7 kHz square wave (`indicators.Buzzer.beep`). An *active* buzzer has its own oscillator and sounds at its own frequency the moment it sees a voltage — so it will make a noise here, just not the one that was chosen.



Prove it

The buzzer is proved by the self-test, which sounds it deliberately and asks what you heard. Stop the service first — it holds the GPIO lines:

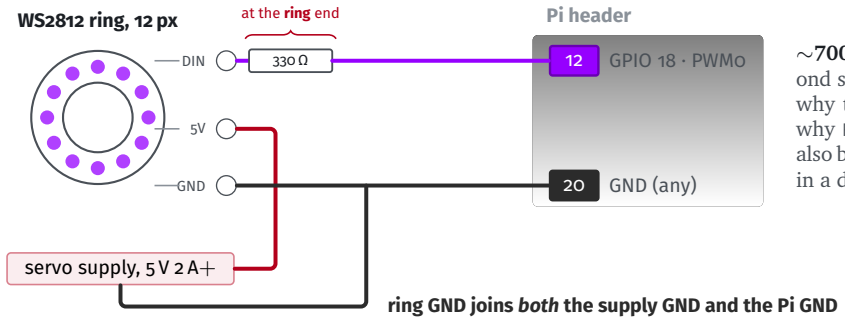
```
sudo systemctl stop snapcare-dispenser
sudo python3 -m snapcare_dispenser --selftest
sudo systemctl start snapcare-dispenser
```

You are listening for a clear *tone*, not a click. A click means an active buzzer with its own oscillator, which makes a noise at whatever frequency it likes rather than the one the firmware asked for — fit a passive piezo element instead.

`POST /api/drop` deliberately does not chirp. A manual drop is somebody checking a hopper at the bench, not a dose anybody has to be fetched for, so it moves the servo and stays silent. The repeating chirp belongs to a *scheduled* dose waiting on a release, and the way to hear it in context is to schedule one a minute out.

9 Stage 3 — the LED ring

This is the first stage that touches the servo supply. The ring's 5 V does *not* come from the Pi.



~700 mA at full white. That is a second servo's worth of current, which is why the ring is on the servo rail and why `RING_BRIGHTNESS` is 60 of 255 — also because full brightness is dazzling in a dark bedroom at 3 a.m.

GPIO 18 is not a free choice

`rpi_ws281x` generates the WS2812's 800 kHz waveform with the PWM or PCM peripheral and the DMA controller, and **GPIO 18, 12, 21 and 10 are the only pins wired to them.** Anything else is a ring that never lights and an error message about DMA. GPIO 18 is PWM0 and is not in the servo map. A test asserts this (`tests/test_servo.py`).

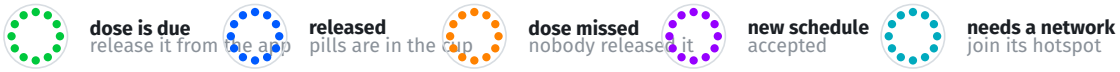
The 330 Ω is not folklore. It damps the reflection on the first data edge, which is what makes the first pixel latch a wrong colour on a long lead. It has to be at the ring end to do that.

Prove it

```
sudo systemctl restart snapcare-dispenser
curl -s http://localhost/api/status     # "indicators" should now list the ring
curl -X POST http://localhost/api/schedule \
     -H 'Content-Type: application/json' \
     -d '{"payload":"SC1*W*1:0800-127-030"}'   # violet: schedule accepted
```

If the ring stays dark, check `journalctl` — a ring that throws is dropped and logged rather than retried forever, and the status page reports what is actually fitted rather than pretending.

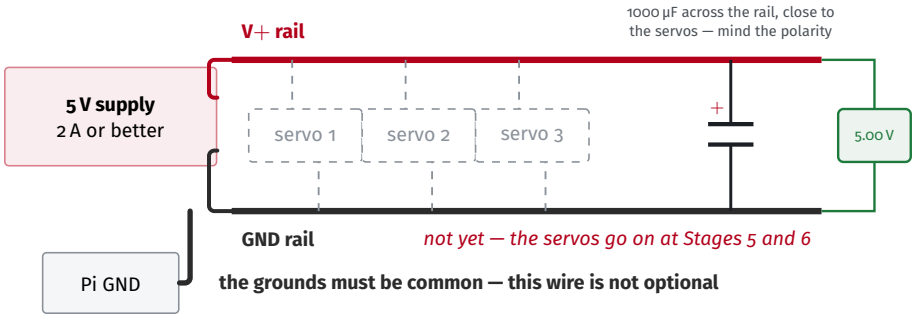
The colour vocabulary you have just fitted. Never text, because the person the machine is for cannot be assumed to read.



Green now means one step earlier than it used to. On the Arduino build green meant "there are pills in the cup". Here it means "there is a dose you can have", and blue is what follows once somebody has taken it. Only green chirps.

10 Stage 4 — the servo power rail, before any servo

Wire and measure the rail with **no servos attached and no signal wires to the Pi**. This is the stage that protects the SD card.



Do not run the servos from the Pi's 5 V pin

One SG90 stalls at around 700 mA. The failure is not a blown regulator; it is a brown-out, and **a Pi that browns out mid-write corrupts an SD card** — where the file being written is the one that records whether a dose has already been given.

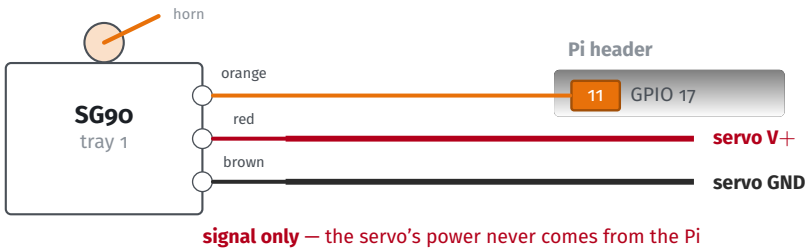
The common ground is what makes the signal mean anything. Without it the servos twitch or ignore commands entirely, which reads as a firmware fault and is not one. The bulk capacitor absorbs the current step when a servo starts, which is what otherwise dips the rail.

Prove it

Meter across the rail. **5 V ±0.25 V, steady.** Nothing else is connected yet, so anything else is the supply or the wiring, not the firmware.

11 Stage 5 — one servo

Do one, entirely, before the others.

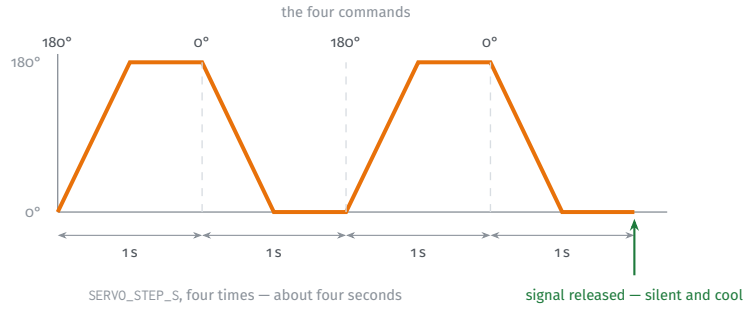


Prove it

```
sudo systemctl restart snapcare-dispenser
curl -X POST http://localhost/api/drop \
     -H 'Content-Type: application/json' -d '{"tray":1}'
```

The tray rests at 0°. A drop is four commands from there — 180°, 0°, 180°, 0°— one second apart, so about four seconds in total. Then the signal to that pin is **cut** rather than held — so the servo should go silent and cool between doses.

Why the stroke runs twice. One tip does not reliably clear the gate: a pill can sit on the lip and ride back with the horn, which reads as a dose given and is not one. The second round trip is what shakes it through.



Check which driver you got. `gpio.servo` in the status says which library came up and how its pulses are timed:

```
curl -s http://localhost/api/status | grep -i -A3 servo
```

`timing`	Verdict	What it means
`dma`	best	pigpio. Pulses timed by the DMA controller, immune to CPU load. Only on a Bookworm card
`threaded`	fine	lgpio, the normal answer on a current image. Timed in C below Python; the occasional twitch under heavy load
`python`	jittery	RPi.GPIO's software PWM, timed from a Python thread. Every kernel preemption is a visible twitch and an audible buzz — `sudo apt install python3-lgpio`
`none`	nothing moves	No GPIO library at all. The firmware refuses to dispense rather than logging doses that never came out

12 Stage 6 — the remaining servos

Tray	GPIO	Header pin
1	17	11
2	27	13
3	22	15
4	5	29
5	6	31
6	13	33
7	19	35
8	26	37

Work down this table for as many hoppers as the machine has. Nothing in the firmware says how many that is — all eight are accepted by default, and every pin here is already checked for clashes and against the pins that cost hardware. A hopper added next month is a plug and nothing else.

Wire them one at a time and prove each before the next. The trade-off that the default buys is below.

What "all eight by default" costs, and how to buy it back

An SG90 reports nothing, so there is no way for the firmware to tell a fitted hopper from an empty pin. Accepting all eight means a schedule naming a tray this machine does not physically have is **accepted** — and that dose is then never dispensed and reported by nothing. No jam, no error, a status page that looks perfectly healthy.

On a machine that will not grow, say how many are fitted and the firmware refuses such a schedule by name, while somebody is still looking at the screen that sent it:

```
sudo systemctl edit snapcare-dispenser     # add: Environment=SNAPCARE_TRAYS=2
```

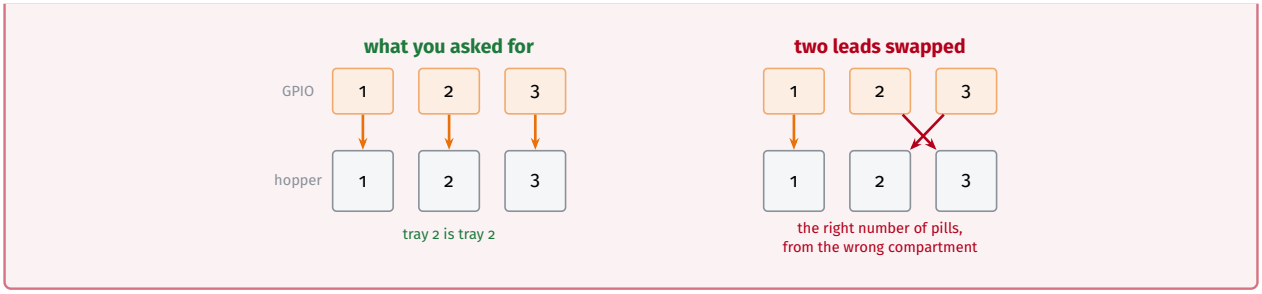
Prove it

Prove each one *individually*, and watch which hopper actually moves. Set `TRAYS` to the number you fitted — the sleep is longer than one drop, so the moves stay separated and you can see which is which:

```
TRAYS=2
for t in $(seq 1 $TRAYS); do
  curl -X POST http://localhost/api/drop \
       -H 'Content-Type: application/json' -d "{\"tray\":$t}"
  sleep 6
done
```

This is the one worth doing carefully

Two trays on one pin gives the right number of pills from the wrong compartment, and **nobody notices that until the wrong medication has been taken for a week.** The firmware refuses a duplicate pin at startup, but it cannot check that the wire you plugged into GPIO 27 goes to the hopper you are calling tray 2.



Only one servo is ever driven at a time, enforced by a lock — two trays released together still move one horn at a time. Eight SG90s starting together is a current step that reboots the Pi with a compartment open.

13 Stage 7 — mechanical fitting and trim

Fit the hoppers with the servos at their **resting 0°**, not wherever the horn happened to stop. Park each one there first, then mount the horn:

```
sudo systemctl stop snapcare-dispenser
sudo python3 -m snapcare_dispenser --drop 1     # sweeps, and ends at rest
```



If a tray does not quite reach its stop, or buzzes at the end of the stroke because it is being driven past it, trim *that tray alone*:

```
SERVO_TRIM = {3: (520, 2450)}    # config.py -- overrides only tray 3
```

> **Buzzing at the end of a stroke is the one to act on**
>
> It is the servo fighting a mechanical stop it has already reached, and it is what burns one out over a few weeks.

The other knob, if a full hopper is slower than an empty one:

```
SERVO_STEP_S = 1.0     # seconds between one command in the stroke and the next
```

This is the whole timing model. Nothing on an SG90 reports position, so the firmware is simply waiting out the clock, and the interval must cover the *slowest* case — a cold servo under the weight of a full tray, about half a second — and still leave the hopper time to settle before the horn reverses. Raising it lengthens the drop by four times whatever you add.

> **Prove it**
>
> This is the first point at which the whole machine can be run end to end. Restart the service, schedule a dose a minute or two out, and *do not touch anything*:

```
sudo systemctl start snapcare-dispenser
curl -s http://localhost/api/status      # read "now", then pick a time 2 min later
curl -X POST http://localhost/api/schedule \
     -H 'Content-Type: application/json' -d '{"payload":"SC1*W*1:HHMM-127-000"}'
```

At `HHMM` the ring should go green and the buzzer should start chirping, and **no tray should open**. Then release it:

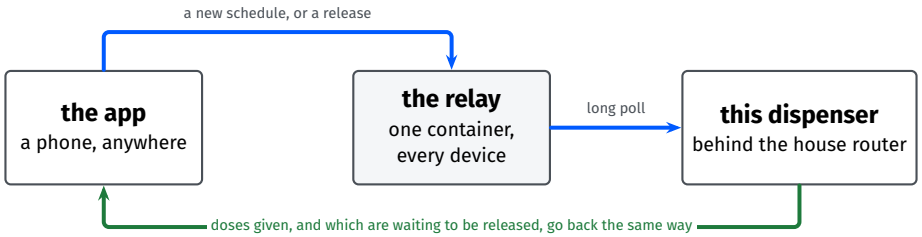
```
curl -s http://localhost/api/status | grep -i awaitingRelease
curl -X POST http://localhost/api/release -H 'Content-Type: application/json' -d '{}'
```

Now the tray sweeps and the ring goes blue. If you would rather see the other branch, leave it alone for the full grace hour: the tray must stay shut and the ring must go amber.

14 Stage 8 — cloud sync, if you want it

Skip this stage entirely and the dispenser still works, on one condition: the phone has to be on the house WiFi to release a dose. That is a reasonable way to ship one, and it is the whole machine — the schedule arrives from the app over the LAN or off a photographed paper sheet, and the device runs it from the SD card against the DS1302.

What this stage adds is that both directions work from anywhere: a schedule edited by a carer across town arrives **without anybody being in the house**, and a release tapped on a notification reaches the device from a train.



the relay is *not* a part in the bill of materials:
one container, deployed once, serving every dispenser you build

See `../cloud_relay/README.md`. Then name it here:

```
curl -X POST http://localhost/api/cloud \
     -H 'Content-Type: application/json' \
     -d '{"relayUrl":"https://snapcare-relay.fly.dev"}'
```

or type it into the device's own console, or set `SNAPCARE_RELAY_URL` in the systemd unit if you are building more than one.

Prove it

```
curl -s http://localhost/api/status     # the "cloud" object
```

`state` should reach `connected` within a few seconds, with `lastError` empty and `reportedRev` at 1 or more — that last one is the device having published its own state, which is what creates its mailbox.

> Then prove both directions from the relay's demo app: open `https://<your relay>/lab`, pair with this device's code, send it a schedule, and — once a dose is due — release it from there. The schedule should appear in `payload` within a second or two, and the release should open the tray about as fast.

If it does not:

`state`	What it means
`connecting`	The first poll is in flight. This is what you see first, for a second or two
`unpaired`	No relay URL. The POST above did not take, or was sent to the wrong host
`unsupported`	`python3-cryptography` is missing. `sudo apt install python3-cryptography`
`retrying`	The relay is not answering. `lastError` says why — usually DNS or a firewall
`offline`	It was reachable and has not been for fifteen minutes
`off`	Switched off — `--no-cloud`, or `SNAPCARE_CLOUD=0`

The test nobody does: unplug the internet, not the device

Pull the router's WAN cable, leave the dispenser and the phone on the LAN, and release a due dose from the app. The pill must still come out.

This matters more than it did before the release model. A build that has just gained a cloud feature is exactly when a dependency on it gets introduced by accident — and now that dependency would not merely delay a report, it would mean the tray cannot be opened at all. The symptom is a machine that works perfectly in every test anyone runs at a desk.

A release is not a schedule, and the relay carries it differently. The schedule lives in a slot the device treats as *state*: whatever is newest is what it should be running, so a device coming back after a week adopts it. A release is an *act* — true for one hour on one morning — so it has a slot of its own, and the device carries one out only if the dose it names is one it is offering right now.

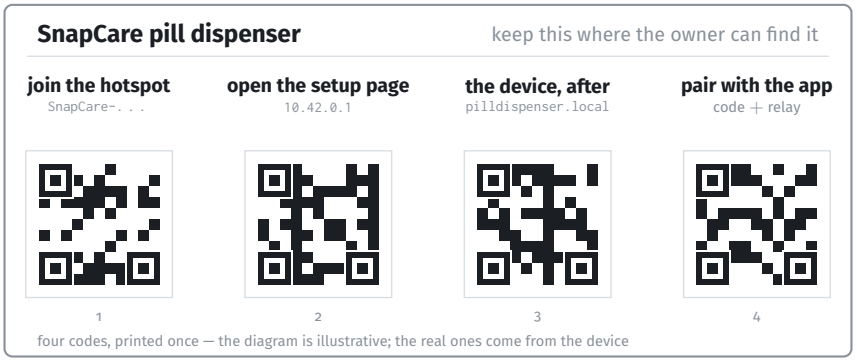
That is what stops a release tapped at 08:05 and delivered at 3 p.m., by a relay that was down in between, from dropping a pill into an empty room.

15 Stage 9 — the label

The setup code is printed once and never changes. It is derived, not generated: HMAC-SHA256 over the SoC serial in `/proc/cpuinfo`, so it survives a reimage and differs per board. The pairing code on it comes from the same derivation, so it is permanent in the same way.

```
sudo python3 -m snapcare_dispenser --show-qr      # scannable, in the terminal
```

or print the proper one from `http://pilldispenser.local/label`.



The pairing code is a credential

Anyone who can read it can send this device a schedule *and release a dose*, in the same way anyone who can read the WiFi password can join the hotspot. Put the label where the owner can find it and a visitor cannot — inside a battery door, or on the underside.

The one part of the label that is not permanent

The pairing QR encodes *your relay's address* alongside the code, because that is what makes a phone camera able to open it. Move to a different relay and that QR points at the old one. The code printed beside it in text still works — it is derived from the board, not from the relay — so the fix is to reprint, not to re-pair. If you expect to move relays, print the label with no relay configured: the QR then carries the code alone, which the app can read and a plain camera cannot.

16 The whole pin map, in one place

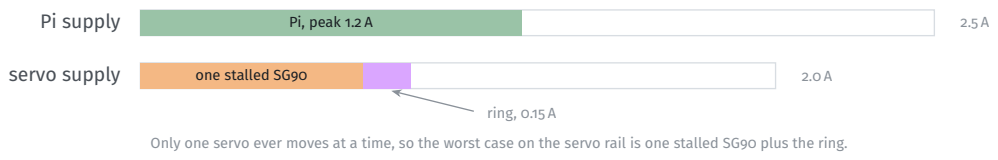
Signal	GPIO (BCM)	Header pin	Notes
Servo tray 1	17	11	signal only — **not** power
Servo tray 2	27	13	
Servo tray 3	22	15	
Servo trays 4–8	5, 6, 13, 19, 26	29, 31, 33, 35, 37	same status as the first three; fit a hopper and it works
Piezo buzzer	23	16	through 100 Ω
WS2812 ring data	18	12	through 330 Ω at the ring; must be 18/12/21/10
DS1302 SCLK	16	36	bit-banged; no bus, no kernel driver
DS1302 I/O	20	38	bidirectional — 3.3 V only
DS1302 CE	21	40	
DS1302 VCC	—	17 (3.3 V)	not 5 V
Ground	—	6, 9, 14, 20, 25, 30, 34, 39	pin 39 to the RTC; at least one to the servo supply GND
free	4, 24, 25	7, 18, 22	unassigned. GPIO 24 carried the confirm button on earlier builds

Run `pinout` on the Pi for the full header. Everything above is BCM numbering, which is what both GPIO libraries use.

17 Power budget

Two supplies, and the split is the point.

Rail	Load	Draw
Pi supply (5 V 2.5 A)	Pi 3B with WiFi active	~0.4 A idle, ~1.2 A peak
Servo supply (5 V 2 A+)	one SG90, moving	~0.2 A typical, ~0.7 A stalled
Servo supply	WS2812 ring, 12 px at brightness 60	~0.15 A (≈0.7 A at full white)



Figures for the servo and the ring are the ones the firmware was designed around; the Pi's are the usual published ranges. Meter your own rail if you change the ring size. Only one servo ever moves at a time, so the tray count does not move these figures.

18 Commissioning

Run this before the device goes anywhere near real medication.

```
sudo systemctl stop snapcare-dispenser
sudo python3 -m snapcare_dispenser --selftest
sudo systemctl start snapcare-dispenser
```

It checks what can be checked, asks about what only eyes and ears can settle, and writes a report to `/var/lib/snapcare/commissioning.json`. It opens trays, so it says so and waits for you to agree first.

Why this is not a paper checklist any more. The list this replaced was a good list with a structural problem: most of its claims were not things a person can actually observe.

"Servos silent and cool a few seconds after a drop" is a real failure with a real consequence and it is unanswerable three stages later, so the self-test waits three seconds after the last stroke and asks then. "Every tray you fitted moves" is ticked truthfully by a machine whose trays 1 and 2 are wired to each other's pins — both moved — so the self-test asks *which hopper moved*, by number. And "the buzzer works" is ticked by an active buzzer playing the wrong note, so it asks whether you heard a tone or a click.

The rule it follows throughout: never ask about something it did not just make happen.

It reports in four states, and the last is the one worth reading:

`ok`	Checked and correct
`FAIL`	Checked and wrong, with the fix beside it
`warn`	True but not blocking — a Python-timed servo, a tray count left at the default
`skip`	**Nobody looked.** "Everything passed" and "everything anybody looked at passed" are different sentences, and this is the difference

Six things it cannot do, which are the six that matter most. Each needs the power, the network or the calendar interfered with, and each is invisible in any test run at a desk:

Test	What it catches
The power cut	Pull the power at 08:30, after the 08:00 dose has been released, and restore it. No second dose, and the log survives. This is exactly the case that dispenses twice without persisted state
The coin cell	Unplug the Pi, leave it a minute, bring it back with the network unplugged. `clock.trusted` must still be true and `clock.source` must read `rtc`. Nothing on a bench with WiFi proves this, because NTP vouches first and the RTC is never consulted
The dose nobody takes	Let a scheduled dose sit for its whole grace window without releasing it. The tray must stay shut, the log must say missed, and the ring must go amber. A build that quietly drops it at the end has lost the point of asking first
The stale notification	Let a dose expire, then tap release on a notification still sitting on the phone's lock screen. Nothing must move — the device's own sense of what is due is the authority, and this is the only way to watch it refuse
The internet cut	Pull the router's WAN cable, leave the dispenser and the phone on the LAN, and release a due dose. It must come out. This catches a release path that only works through the relay, which passes every test at a desk
The wrong password	Type the WiFi password wrong on purpose. The setup network must come back within a few seconds and the page you re-open must say the password was not accepted

And two more if the machine will be left with somebody:

- ☐ Change the router's password, reboot the device, wait: the setup hotspot appears on its own rather than the device sitting there unreachable
- ☐ Power the router and the device off together and bring only the device back for a few minutes first. It raises its hotspot, then finds the router by itself once that returns — no hands

19 When it does not work

Symptom	Look at
Releasing a dose	
The ring goes green and chirps, but no release button appears in the app	The app has not heard about the dose. On the LAN, check `pilldispenser.local` resolves from the phone; through the relay, check `cloud.state` is `connected`. `device.awaitingRelease` in `/api/status` is what the app is waiting to see
Tapping release does nothing, and the ring stays green	`device.blockedReason` says which of the two gates it is: an untrusted clock, or no GPIO library. They need opposite fixes
Tapping release says nothing was waiting	The window closed — `GRACE_MINUTES`, one hour by default. The dose is in the log as `not-released`. This is correct behaviour, not a fault
Doses expire untaken every day	Nobody is being told. Almost always a missing buzzer: check `gpio.missing`. On this build the chirp is the prompt, not an announcement
The release works at home and not away	That is the LAN path working and the relay path not. Stage 8, and `cloud.state`
Installing	
`install.sh` stops at "could not get lock `/var/lib/dpkg/lock-frontend`"	Another package manager is running — on a freshly imaged card that is almost always `unattended-upgrades`, which fires on a timer a few minutes after first boot. Nothing was changed; the script now waits up to five minutes instead of stopping. Watch it finish with `systemctl list-jobs` or just run the installer again in a few minutes
The installer waits, then still gives up	The other job is a long one, not a stuck one. `sudo systemctl stop unattended-upgrades` if you would rather not wait, or raise the timeout with `SNAPCARE_APT_WAIT_S=900 sudo -E ./service/install.sh`. **Do not delete the lock file** — it does not release the lock, and it breaks the package database
Servos	
Servo twitches or ignores commands	Common ground. The Pi's GND and the servo supply GND must be joined
Servo hums between doses	You are on the RPi.GPIO fallback — `sudo apt install python3-lgpio`. `gpio.servo.timing` in `/api/status` says which you have: `dma`, `threaded` or `python`
Nothing moves and no error appears	No GPIO library at all. The firmware refuses to dispense rather than logging doses that never came out — `gpio.missing` says so. `sudo apt install python3-lgpio`
`apt install pigpio` says there is no such package	Correct, on Raspberry Pi OS Trixie. It is not coming back; lgpio is the driver now
Servo buzzes at the end of a stroke	Being driven past its mechanical stop. Trim it in `SERVO_TRIM` before it burns out
Pi reboots when a servo moves	Servos are on the Pi's 5 V pin, or the rail has no bulk capacitor
Ring and buzzer	
Ring never lights, DMA error in the log	Data line is not on GPIO 18/12/21/10

Symptom	Look at
First pixel is the wrong colour	330 Ω missing, or at the Pi end instead of the ring end. If it persists, the ring's 5 V logic threshold ($0.7 \times V_{DD} = 3.5$ V) is above the Pi's 3.3 V output — shorten the lead, or drop the ring's supply to ∼4.5 V
Ring flickers only when a servo moves	pigpio and the ring contending for PWM. pigpiod's `-t` selects its clock peripheral: `-t 1` is PCM, which is the default and the one that leaves PWM0 free for the ring. `-t 0` selects PWM and is the setting that *causes* this
Buzzer makes a tone but not *this* tone	It is an active buzzer with its own oscillator. Use a passive element
Ring is cyan and stays cyan	The device is on its own setup hotspot waiting to be put on a network. Join `SnapCare-. . .` and the page opens itself
Clock and schedule	
Clock right at shutdown, wrong at boot	The cell is dead or not seated. `clock.rtc.detail` distinguishes "never been set" from "the cell has been flat since"
`clock.rtc` says "no record of ever having been set", and still does after a reboot	The chip has never been written. Check `journalctl -u snapcare-dispenser | grep -i "clock chip"` — a seed is logged whenever NTP first synchronises and every `RTC_RESEED_S` after that. If nothing appears, no trustworthy clock has been available to write down
The RTC never changes after a `shutdown` and a boot	A shutdown leaves the board powered, so the chip never ran on its cell and nothing was being tested. Pull the plug instead
Clock drifts a few minutes a month	Expected — the DS1302's crystal is uncompensated. Leave the device able to reach NTP
A schedule is refused by tray number	This build was told how many trays it has. Raise `SNAPCARE_TRAYS`, or drop it to use all eight
A dose for a tray that was never fitted is never offered, and nothing complains	All eight are accepted by default and an SG90 reports nothing. Set `SNAPCARE_TRAYS` to the number really fitted
A schedule POST answers 421	The `Host` header is not a name this device answers to. Use `pilldispenser.local` or the IP; `SNAPCARE_EXTRA_HOSTS` adds a router's own domain
Network and cloud	
`pilldispenser.local` does not resolve	avahi, and the hostname. The web app's `DEFAULT_HOST` is that exact string
Setup page says "did not hand out an address"	The password was right and DHCP was not. Usually a router that needs restarting, or a MAC filter
The setup hotspot keeps disappearing for half a minute	That is the unattended retry finding a saved network worth trying. It stops once one works; raise `HOTSPOT_RETRY_S` if it is in the way of a bench session
Setup page never leaves "waiting…"	The phone has not gone back to the house WiFi. Switch it over; the page follows. If the device's own network reappeared, the password was refused
Cloud `state: unsupported`	`sudo apt install python3-cryptography`. Everything else still works meanwhile
Cloud `state: retrying`, DNS in `lastError`	The Pi has no working resolver. It joined the WiFi but got no DNS, or the router blocks it
Cloud connects, but no schedule ever arrives	The app is paired to a different code. Compare `cloud.deviceId` here with the one the app shows — they must match exactly

Symptom	Look at
The app shows the device as never seen	Nothing has written to the mailbox. Check `reportedRev` here is 1 or more
A schedule sent from the app is refused	`cloud.lastError` says why, in the same words the LAN API would use. Usually a tray that is not fitted
Cloud fine, but doses take minutes to appear in the log	`SNAPCARE_CLOUD_IDLE_S` is set. That is the cheap mode working as asked — it does not delay releases, which are polled continuously either way

Nothing here needs the hardware to reproduce the *logic* side of it:

```
make            # the full suite, no board, no servos, no network
make run        # the whole firmware on a laptop, mock servos, port 8099
make -C .. demo # the same, plus a relay and the demo app on localhost:8088
```

`make run` is the real firmware with the servo driver swapped for one that only records what it was told, and `make demo` adds a relay and a browser page that pairs with it — so the whole cloud path, including its failure cases, can be exercised without a Raspberry Pi anywhere.